

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the ninth time on 14 August 2023.

Members noted the update provided by Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, on progress achieved since the last meeting in attracting, skilling, retaining and protecting workers in the agriculture and processing industries.

Members discussed opportunities to improve safety outcomes in agriculture and meat processing sectors and requested that Skills Insight develop a voluntary, standardised meat processing industry safety induction program. Members also agreed that workplace safety will be a core component of continued tripartite engagement.

Members discussed issues around existing worker protection strategies and programs and noted work being progressed by the Fair Farms program. Members recognised the value of a tripartite approach to improving workplace standards and worker protection and agreed to continue to pursue tripartism in the future.

Members received an update on the development of the Employment White Paper from Victoria Anderson, Deputy Secretary at the Department of the Treasury. This update included reflections from Treasury on the insights they had gained from observing meetings of the Working Group.

Members acknowledged the importance of food and fibre education, including receiving a presentation from Luciano Mesiti, Chief Executive Officer, and Dr Cameron Archer, Chair on the work of the Primary Industries Education Foundation Australia and progress on the direction of the National Food and Fibre Education Strategy Working Group. Members expressed their support for the National Food Fibre and Education plan, as an important step to encourage young Australians to pursue agricultural careers.

Members received a presentation from the Hon Tony Burke MP, Minister for Employment and Workplace Relations, on key reform initiatives being progressed in his portfolio, for example closing the labour hire loopholes, changes to the PALM scheme, a national framework for labour hire regulation and strengthened protections for workers. Members welcomed the opportunity to provide input directly into these measures, including on features of importance to the agriculture and processing sectors and their workers.

Members agreed there is value in continued tripartite engagement on agricultural workforce issues and opportunities beyond the life of the Working Group. Members had an initial discussion about the format of this engagement and noted that a more detailed proposal would be considered at the next meeting.

The Working Group will next meet in September 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry

- Joseph Mitchell, Assistant Secretary, Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Fiona Simson, President, National Farmers' Federation
- Tony Mahar, Chief Executive Officer, National Farmers' Federation
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Tim Nelthorpe, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, Chief Executive Officer, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council
- Cindy Briscoe, Acting Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

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